

FIRST & TEN

* Denotes PPT Slide

* Denotes instruction to technician

INTRO: I love college football. I am not much of a pro football fan, I have a hard time watching a bunch of millionaires run up and down the field with ego's bigger than the game itself. With that said, I do like watching the super bowl.

Not having played football in school what I know about the game has been learned from watching others play it. (Have those who have played the game to stand – Junior high – High school – College – Pro – Who has coached football? Who has served as an official in the game?) My knowledge of the game is limited because I have never coached the game or played it. The gentlemen who just stood know far more

about the game than I.

Even though my knowledge of the game is limited, I do know the following things:

- Each team gets four downs...
- Three of those downs are used in an attempt to get a first down or to score...
- Depending on where the ball is positioned on the field, fourth down is used to kick a field goal, punt, or to take the risk of picking up a first down...
- Depending on where the ball is located on the field the risk of going for a fourth down can be minimal or considered high risk...

Coaches are adamant about making first downs. Making a first down is the most important thing in football! A first down allows the team to achieve a new set of downs so that they continue their

movement toward the goal line and six points. I love long passes and long runs; I love pick sixes; these things are filled with excitement, but making first downs is how you win a football game.

Coaches emphasize picking up good yardage on first down so that they don't face third and long. Facing third and long places the team in a very vulnerable position. Third and long is where many interceptions and fumbles occur.

In his book *Football At Ohio State* Woody Hayes states "*Our offensive football is based upon the principle that we must first establish a sound running game. We have learned through experience and intensive play of Big 10 football, that the team with the better running game will most likely win the game.*" Hayes then states the key

ingredient in winning football games:
"We use the word consistency to denote the success of a play. For a play to be consistent it has to be one which has gained at least three yards." He went on to state, *"Since one of the three plays will more than likely gain more than just three yards, the net result will be the possession of the ball!"*

(Talk about first& ten signal – Have the people to make a first & ten signal with each point)

If a team can pick up three and one half yards on each of the three downs of each series of plays, they score a touchdown every time! That doesn't sound like a very thrilling game but it is the most effective thing a team can do.

In our lives we love catching a long pass that ends in instant gratification. We love picking up a fumble and running it into

the end zone. These things make for great testimonies.

When it comes to our lives, I do not believe God is as interested in the high octane plays as he is in first downs that move the ball of life toward the goal line. God wants us to live very methodical lives that pick up three and one half yards each play, so that we don't end up in a third and long, or worse yet in a fourth and desperate!

This morning I am going to give you three plays that if followed every day will end in first & ten every time. The result of this kind of living ultimately guarantees the believer a touchdown on every series! [Proverbs 3:5-6 \(NKJV\)](#)

“Trust in the Lord with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding; 6 In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall

direct your paths."

FIRST DOWN PLAY: TRUST IN THE LORD WITH ALL OF YOUR HEART

For the unsaved, it is God's will that you get saved. You cannot trust the Lord until you come to know the Lord.

For the believer trusting the Lord takes on new meaning. **To trust the Lord means: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- I place my life in His hands and allow Him to call all the plays...
- I refuse to allow worry to overcome me because I know He has a plan for a first & ten...
- I praise Him during the test because I know He is going to bring about a first & ten despite the circumstances...

QUOTE: *“When a train goes through a tunnel & it gets dark, you don't throw away the ticket & jump off. You sit still & trust the engineer!”* (Corrine Ten Boom)

We are not just trusting in the Lord; we are trusting in Him with all of our heart! We have burned the bridges of retreat behind us and we are going with the play He has called, no matter what!

SECOND DOWN PLAY: LEAN NOT TO YOUR OWN UNDERSTANDING

If we are going to continue toward the goal line rather than having to punt we must get God involved on the front end, rather than on the back end.

God has given us His playbook we should use it before calling a play! His Word is like traffic or directional signs. Ignore them and you run the risk of

having to punt!

Our problem is that we want to run our own plays on the first three downs. This results in three plays and a cloud of dust!

On fourth and long we expect God to facilitate a Hail Mary! When the Hail Mary fails, we become frustrated and blame God for our failures. Life has a way of getting us into difficult predicaments. I refer to it as the battering ram of life. Life will beat the living daylights out of you if you allow it.

QUOTE: *"It's not the load that breaks you down, it's the way you carry it."* (CS Lewis)

How do we go about handling the battering ram of life differently? Rather than looking into His play book on fourth down we should follow His instructions

on first, second, and third down. When we operate in this fashion we will have less need to find a fourth down play because He will give us a first & ten.

THIRD DOWN PLAY: IN ALL YOUR WAYS ACKNOWLEDGE HIM

The word “Acknowledge” comes from the Hebrew word (yada) which means to “*Know.*” In Genesis 4:25 “***Adam knew (yada) his wife, and she bare a son.***” this speaks of getting to know God intimately. If we know God intimately and experientially through His Word we reach a place where His will is intuitive to us. In this place we rarely need a booming voice from the sky, all we need is a gentle impression.

When we acknowledge Him, we allow Him to be involved in every area of our decision-making. We do not make

decisions without His involvement. (I once bought a car without Susan knowing it or getting her input!!!!)

CONCLUSION:

When we meet these conditions, God states the consequence: ***“He shall direct your path.”***

The word ***“direct”*** comes from the Hebrew word yashar, meaning to make straight or smooth. This word is used in Isaiah 40:3 to describe the future ministry of John the Baptist who would ***“make straight [Hebrew yashar] in the desert a highway for our God.”***

In Isaiah’s time, the way one country rolled out the red carpet for a visiting king was to send road workers to:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Fill in potholes - ***“Every valley shall be exalted.”***

- Shave down the big bumps - ***“Every mountain and hill shall be made low.”***
- Straighten the bends in the road ***“The crooked shall be made straight.”***

QUOTE: *“God didn't give you the strength to get back on your feet only to run back to the very thing that knocked you down. It's not a good idea to pick up something God helped you put away.”*
(unknown)

When we enact His plays on first, second, and third down, God will direct our path to success. When He is in charge every third down will result in an first & ten; first & ten's result in touchdowns; touchdowns result in wins; wins result in the championship trophy!